Pathupattu or ten Idylls collection includes ten long songs

(1) *Thirumurugatrupadai*
(2) Porunaratrupadai
(3) Perumpanatruppadai
(4) Sirupanatrupadai
(5) Mullaipaattu
(6) Nedunalvaadai
(7) Maduraikanchi
(8) Kurinjipaattu
(9) Pattinappaalai
(10) Malaipadukadam

Pathinen Kilkanakku (18 minor works)

The *Pathinen Kilkanakku* comprises eighteen texts elaborating on ethics and morals. The pre-eminent work among these is the *Thirukkural* composed by Thiruvalluvar. In 1330 couplets *Thirukkural* considers questions of morality, statecraft and love.

The Five Epics

The epics or *Kappiyams* are long narrative poem of very high quality. They are,

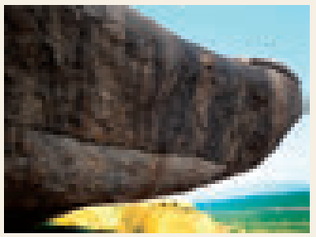
(1) *Silappathikaaram* *(2) Manimekalai*
(3) Seevaka Chinthamani
(4) Valaiyapathi *(5) Kundalakesi*

Epigraphy

Epigraphy is the study of inscriptions. Inscriptions are documents scripted on stone, copper plates, and other media such as coins, rings, etc. The development of script marks the beginning of the historical period.

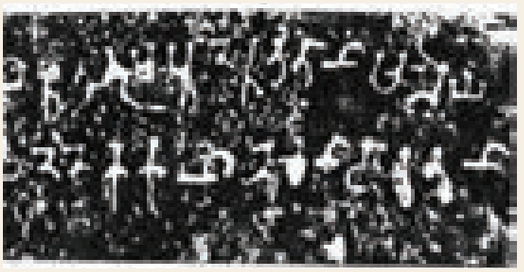
Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions

Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions have been found in more than 30 sites in Tamil Nadu mostly on cave surfaces and rock shelters. These caves were the abodes of monks, mostly Jaina monks. The natural caves were converted into residence by cutting a drip-line to keep rain water away from the cave. Inscriptions often occur below such drip-lines. The sites have smooth stone beds carved on rock surface for monks who led a simple life and lived in these shelters. Merchants and kings converted these natural formations as habitation for monks, who had renounced worldly life. Mangulam, Muttupatti, Pugalur, Arachalur and Kongarpuliyankulam and Jambai are some of the major sites of such caves with Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions. Around Madurai many such caves with Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions can still be seen. Many of them are located along ancient trade routes.


A drip-line at a rock cave with Tamil-Brahmi inscription

Note: You will notice that among the old inscriptions, people (both local and tourists) have marked their names thereby destroying some of the ancient inscriptions. Such acts of destruction of heritage property or property belonging to others are called **vandalism**.


The Tamil-Brahmi inscription at Arachalur


Estampage copy of the above inscription


A rock bed at K. Puliankulam

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